2015 AGM
President's Report
(Mondo Kopua)

Since being in the role of President for the past 12 months I have what I consider taken a tentative approach to the role and some of the issues and challenges that Pete Squires identified in his 2013 – 2014 report and that the NZRA group have discussed and grappled with for a few years now.

It certainly has been an interesting period where there have been a variety of issues to get myself familiar with, gain some background and learning, decisions and commitments made and a few things to still be worked through and achieve some outcomes and resolutions.

The cancellation (the first ever) of the 2014 Heights of Winter (HOW) was unfortunate but the right one given the circumstances and extreme weather (and ensuing aftermath) that the area had. The farmers were very appreciate of the sensitivity and decisions made by the organisers. It did highlight that having a Plan B (and possibly a Plan C) as part of the planning process. We are grateful that PAPO have offered us to host the HOW this year.

It was a relief to finally confirm our hosting of the 5th Australasian Championships scheduled for the weekend of 11th - 12th February 2017. We had given an assurance and commitment to the Australian Rogaine Association to host the champs but the original plans were rather protracted and drawn out. We are very fortunate that Bob Cunninghame was able to commit to hosting the Championships. We look forward to being part of the series and expect that several (most likely more) teams from NZ will participate in the other years in Australia. It would be prudent to confirm an organiser and location for 2022 by at least 2020!

The 2014 NZ Championships hosted by the Highland Events team of Ed Stevens and Terry Davis was a great success and an excellent collaboration between a 'commercial business' and a 'club' where both came away with a positive experience. I foresee that more collaboration with 'commercial event organisers', community groups, individuals and fundraisers will be an area where the NZRA and/or the Regional reps, can offer advice and assistance.

Another area requiring greater focus is organising events, notably the NZ Champs but also 12 hour ones as these tend to attract the greatest numbers particularly adventure racers, multisporters and trail runners. 12 hour rogaines are the ideal lead-in for championship level events. Although this duration is more popular and requires less land area I believe that the 24 hour format needs to continue as it is the international standard and are important to keep NZ athletes competitive in the international arena.

In Pete's (amended report) words *"The Australian Rogaining Championships, run annually by one of the State organisations in a rotation…. must meet strict criteria of organisation, vetting, and quality, and we risk losing the ability to provide this if we do not continue to have our own national championships. Organisationally, these events are much more demanding, requiring access to large tracts of land and demanding standards of course-setting, while participation is much lower. Many smaller, local events lack the formality and rigour which build the discipline for both organisers and participants to underpin championship-level rogaining. We need to find ways to improve the flows from the shorter to the longer events."*

The quality and standard of events has improved vastly over the years. With this comes the expectation of higher standards such as for mapping, course setting and control placement, risk management, food etc. I see a need, particularly for NZ Champs events, for course vetters. There are several people in the rogaine community who are capable and experienced who could vet courses. Creating a database of people and providing some support, resources and financial reimbursement will be important requirements.
I believe a key role is that of a NZ Champs Liaison/Co-ordinator. It requires someone that will be proactive with communication, providing linkages between the various contributors, establishing a team and an 'action list' with various tasks, delegated persons or leads is assigned and that regular progress reports and updates are happening in a timely manner and within specified timelines.

Although there was once an agreement with the NZOF (now ONZ) to share the hosting of the NZ Champs we currently take responsibility for these as no orienteering club has been able to commit to hosting a champs event in recent years. While the NZRA has national responsibility in the International rogaine landscape the Association is more of a networker (website, newsletters), promoter and resource provider for rogaining, rather than a prolific organiser of events. The NZRA or more specifically the core group from Christchurch (regional branch potential?) with PAPO host the annual HOW 12 rogaine on alternative years.

There are rogaines, typically 6 hours or less, being run by a diversity of event organisers, groups and individuals in many regions. These attract strong participation across a wide range of people because of their duration, requiring less training and gear etc and for organisers a smaller land area and less organisational needs. We help them where we can or where our assistance is sought.

Associated with this there still remains a mixed view of where rogaining best sits and I suspect those people that wish to have rogaining under the umbrella of Orienteering NZ (ONZ) then this is what will happen while others who consider that the NZRA, whose primary focus is rogaining, will pursue forming a regional branch of NZRA. How and what role, services and structures NZRA will then provide overall and to also support any regional branch will be the next challenge to clarify.

Regional reps and/or branches can act as a contact point for local enquires as well as being responsible for hosting, nurturing and fostering rogaines in their regions. It also allows some autonomy and at the same time can lessen the dependence and reliance of the 'core' group

of the NZRA. Smaller regional branches may attract more engagement from the local community and volunteers. Often local people are more willing to be actively involved at a local level rather than at a national level. Maybe rather optimistically by being involved at a local level some people may become interested in helping at a national level or being co-opted to assist in some way.

I've become acutely aware we require succession if the service and functions of the NZRA is to continue. How we attract people to become involved with the NZRA still remains a challenge. Rogaining, as with many other 'sports' and their committees, have been built on the volunteer system. It's my observation and experience that many /younger' people prefer to be competing than spending too much time on organising and being part of committees. While we need more volunteers I believe we should consider pursuing more engagement with commercial business' enterprises as well as considering financial reimbursement or reward for volunteers, groups, individuals and organisers. With ever increasing demands of life and work volunteers can only do so much.

Kia ora,
Mondo Kopua